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AI Without the Agony? Only If Your Data's Ready

Why Responsible AI Starts with Trustworthy Data Foundation — and What Most Orgs Miss

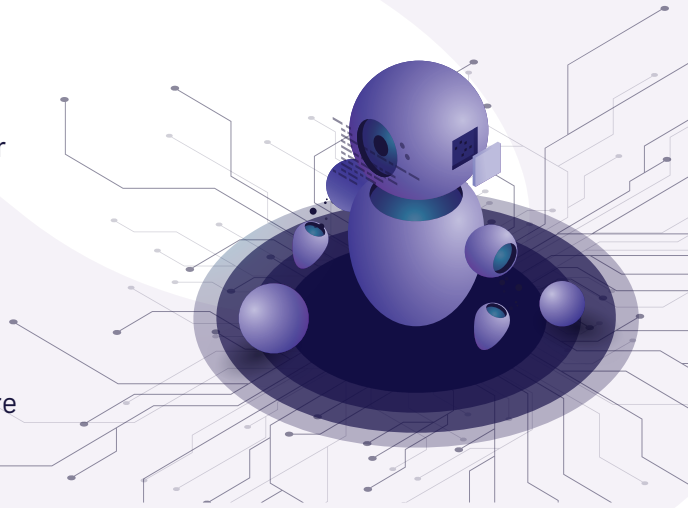
By Manoj Kumar Kakkatil, VP of Technology at WellStack

AI is everywhere in healthcare — but most organizations are still struggling with the basics.

Organizations are eager for decision support, intelligent automation, and predictive insights — but many are building on a foundation of disparate, inconsistent, and often unreliable data. It's a recipe not just for disappointment, but for costly missteps and misinformation.

After decades of building healthcare data platforms, I can say this with certainty: no amount of AI can fix bad data.

If the foundation isn't governed, explainable, and interoperable, your most advanced AI will misfire. That's why responsible AI starts with infrastructure — from identity resolution and code mapping to real-time standardization and cohort definition.



In my work designing healthcare data platforms, I've seen how powerful AI can be when a system moves beyond fragmented dashboards to real-world, embedded decision support. Getting there takes more than a new tool — it requires governed infrastructure, aligned terminology, and systems that evolve with use.

That's the kind of architecture more organizations need to invest in — one where data flows cleanly, logic modules are reusable, and intelligence is delivered at the point of care or operational need.

Here's what I've learned about getting AI right in healthcare — and how to avoid the mistakes that stall so many organizations on their journey.

Everyone Wants AI. Few Are Ready.

AI is on every roadmap. Leadership teams are being pushed to "do something" with it — either for competitive reasons or just to keep up with industry expectations. But the speed of the conversation has outpaced the maturity of most data environments.

Without clean, unified, context-rich data, the smartest model in the world won't help. In fact, it may hurt — by creating misleading indicators, biased insights, or false confidence in the outputs.

Many organizations are starting with the wrong question -

What can we do with AI?

The right question is:

Is our data even ready for AI?

You Can't AI Your Way Out of Bad Data

Healthcare data is notoriously fragmented. Systems don't talk to each other. Terminology is inconsistent. Fields are missing. Identity management is patchy. These gaps don't just slow things down — they create foundational risk.

Imagine trying to build a predictive model to identify at-risk patients — but:

- Diagnoses are coded differently across facilities
- Social determinants are stored in unstructured notes
- Key labs are missing or misfiled
- Claims and clinical data don't align

The result? Your model is drawing conclusions from chaos.

That's not just an IT problem. It's a clinical risk and a governance liability. It's why healthcare AI initiatives so often fail to deliver ROI — or worse, fail quietly.

The New Imperative: Responsible, Embedded AI

Privacy & Security
must be non-negotiable

Explainability
is essential — especially when AI influences care or reimbursement

Governance
must include auditability and human-in-the-loop checkpoints

Privacy & Security
needs to span from data lineage to decision logic

And most importantly, intelligence needs to live where the work happens. Whether in clinical, operational, or financial workflows, embedding AI into frontline tools is the only way to make it useful — and observable.

AI that exists in a silo won't be trusted. And untrusted AI won't be adopted.

The Right Architecture Makes The Difference

Organizations need to invest not just in tooling, but in reusable **logic modules** & learning systems — intelligence layers that evolve with use and improve with feedback.

Architecture matters. Especially when the stakes are this high.

If your foundation is built on reactive data stitching & manual reporting, no amount of AI will rescue it. What's needed is a data foundation that is AI-native by design:

- **Real-time ingestion and mapping with built-in quality checks**
- **Terminology normalization (e.g., via cohort builders, groupers, and code mappers)**
- **A unified data model that supports patient-level intelligence**
- **Governance frameworks that capture how data was used — and what was done with it**
- **Identity resolution and FHIR-native interoperability**

Avoiding the AI Death

Vague goals
e.g., "Do something with AI"

Poor scoping
"Let's build it all from scratch"

No clear ROI
"We'll figure out the value later"

Wrong talent or infrastructures
e.g., "Do something with AI"

Siloed ownership with no cross-functional alignment
with no cross-functional alignment

What to do instead:

Start with data readiness
Audit what's clean, what's missing, and what needs to be standardized.

Pick high-value, low-effort use cases -
especially those that improve speed-to-decision.

Run PoCs with measurable outcomes
Don't launch broadly until the model proves value.

Include business, clinical, IT, and analytics leaders.
If any group is missing, your rollout will stall.

Final Word: Start Smart. Scale Fast.

AI in healthcare isn't about chasing hype. It's about solving real problems — faster, more intelligently, and with more confidence. But that only works if the data behind the scenes is **trusted, governed, and actionable.**

So before you launch the next AI initiative, ask:

Do we trust our data?

Can we explain our logic?

Will this make life better for real people?

If the answer is no — pause. Rebuild your foundation. Then let AI do what it's meant to do: accelerate the right decisions, in the moments that matter.

Nilesh Patil
Chief Growth and strategy Officer, WellStack

Navigating the Shift to Value-Based Care: Strategies for Healthcare Providers

Nilesh Patil, an innovative thought leader in the realms of technology and AI-driven data analytics, boasts a wealth of experience spanning over two decades in these fields. Throughout his extensive career, he has dedicated over a decade to assisting healthcare organizations in the United States, encompassing payers, providers, and healthcare technology companies. His focus has been on steering transformative initiatives in technology, data, and AI to facilitate seamless adaptation to evolving contracting models.

Known for his solution-oriented mindset, Nilesh is highly regarded for identifying purpose-fit and strategic solutions. Currently serving as the Chief Growth and Strategy Officer for WellStack, a Healthcare Data Analytics platform company, he continues to contribute to the forefront of advancements in the industry.